

CLOTHING AND WEAPONS OF AFRICA AND OCEANIA

By the late 19th century, European invaders were firmly established in Africa and the Pacific Basin. Except in the settlements themselves, their presence actually impinged little on the day-to-day lives of the indigenous peoples, who continued to behave much as they had done for centuries. In particular, while firearms sometimes found their way to the indigenous population, the weapons and tactics they used when fighting among themselves remained largely unchanged. This often had horrific consequences when the native warriors tried to resist conquest. Occasionally, however, as at Isandlwana in 1879 when the Zulus defeated the British, superiority in numbers combined with complacency on the part of the imperialists allowed native warriors using traditional weapons to inflict a crushing defeat.

▼ ZULU KNOBKERRIE

Date	19th century
Origin	South Africa
Length	91cm (36in)

Knobkerries were simple hardwood rods with round finials, usually around 10cm (4in) in diameter. Clubs such as these were carried by Zulu warriors together with a short-shafted stabbing spear and stiff cowhide shield.



Hardwood shaft



▲ ZULU IKLWA (STABBING SPEAR)

Date	19th century
Origin	South Africa
Length	1.2m (4ft)

The celebrated Zulu king Shaka was responsible for introducing the short, broad-pointed stabbing spear known as the *iklwa*, which was used along with a shield.



Slits cut in shield with strip of hide threaded through



▲ ZULU HEADDRESS

Date	19th century
Origin	South Africa
Material	Monkey skin, feathers, fur

The warrior's headdress consisted of a decorative skin band that was set over a monkey-skin cap, with flaps for the neck and ears surmounted by further decoration, such as feathers or fur strips.



▲ ZULU UMUTSHA (APRON)

Date	19th century
Origin	South Africa
Material	Cowhide, goathair

The Zulu warrior's *umutsha* (apron or loincloth) covered his front and back. This example is decorated with goathair, and the pattern would have been unique to an *amabutho* (regiment).



Carved geometric design

◀ ZULU SHIELD

Date	19th century
Origin	South Africa

The Zulu warrior aimed to use the left side of his shield to hook the adversary's shield aside, exposing his body to a spear thrust. The pointed lower end of the shield-shaft was also employed as a weapon.